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‘Irfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

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Book Two · Expanded edition

DRAFT — not for distribution

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Seeking, not powers: what ‘Irfan is

A mysterious subject

Few words in religious life are as easily misunderstood as “mysticism”. The lecture series behind this book opens by admitting as much. Mysticism, it says, is very mysterious: no one really knows what it is, and even the mystics themselves are often unsure what they are doing, “except the real mystics”. So this first chapter does not yet teach the method of ‘Irfan. It asks an earlier question. What is Islamic mysticism after? And why should a believer who already prays, fasts and gives what is due care about it at all?

The Islamic name for the subject is *‘Irfan*. In this book it means the discipline of knowing God through spiritual experience and the purification of the soul. The word shares its root with *ma‘rifah*, a word most readers will know from majalis and du‘as: knowing God, and recognising Him. The Word Study below looks at the family of words more closely. For now it is enough to notice that the name itself points to knowledge, not to power, and that this is the theme of the whole chapter.

ع WORD STUDY: ‘IRFAN AND MA‘RIFAH

The Arabic root [‘]*r-f* carries the sense of knowing and recognising something, often a thing one comes to know by acquaintance rather than by description [VER-IFY: Arabic lexicon, e.g. Lane’s Lexicon, entry [‘]*r-f*]. From it come *ma‘rifah* (knowledge,



recognition), *‘arif* (one who knows) and its plural *‘urafa*, and *‘Irfan*, the name of the discipline. The same root appears in the Quran when it says that God made human beings into peoples and tribes “so that you may come to know one another” [VERIFY: Q 49:13, Qara’i translation]. The lectures define *‘Irfan* simply as “possessing *ma‘rifah*”, the knowledge of God, while knowledge of worldly matters is called *‘ilm*. They add that religious texts often use the two words interchangeably; the finer distinction between them is taken up in Chapter 2. An *‘arif*, then, is not someone who knows many facts about God. It is someone who knows God.

Part of the difficulty is that mysticism is not limited to Islam. There are Christian, Hindu and Buddhist mystics, and even some people with no religion at all feel drawn to it. People also come to mysticism for very different reasons. Some want extraordinary powers. They want, for example, to be in two places at the same time, and so they set out to explore the hidden world of the human soul in order to gain some power from it. The lectures say that this kind of mysticism is found in other religions. Their point is that it must be clearly told apart from the real thing, and that this is “very important”.

So the first questions are basic ones. What are we talking about? Who are the mystics? What do they want from a journey that the lectures describe as “exhausting, time consuming, life consuming”? The answer comes from two places: the Quran, and the words of the Imams (‘a), especially their supplications. There, the lectures argue, we meet a kind of mysticism “very different” from what is found in other religions. This chapter follows that answer. Its conclusion can be given at the start, in the lecture’s own closing words: Islamic mysticism “is actually seeking and nothing else”.

Why go beyond the minimum?

The lectures begin with an honest challenge. Someone once came to the Prophet ﷺ and said, in effect: I don’t have the eagerness to pray *salat al-layl* (the recommended night prayer) or to keep the recommended fasts. If I pray my five daily prayers, fast in Ramadan, pay my zakat and go to hajj once, will I go to *janna* (Paradise)? The Prophet said yes. If you do these things, you will go to *janna*. [VERIFY: the lecture gives no source. Locate the hadith. The best-known version, in which a Bedouin asks about prayer, fasting, zakat and hajj with no mention of *wilaya* or *khums*, is chiefly a Sunni report. Find a Shia-transmitted version, or acknowledge the point for Shia readers.]



The lecture presses the point. If it is so easy to reach janna just by performing our *wajib* (obligatory) duties, why should anyone work so hard? Why take on the long, difficult striving that mysticism asks for? Why bother with what is *mustahabb* (recommended), such as the night prayer and the extra fasts, if the door to Paradise is already open to those who do the minimum?

This is not just a thought experiment. The lectures note that some Muslim jurists and activists are “completely against mysticism”. Their argument is simple: follow what the *shari‘a*, the outward religious law, has told you and you will reach janna; “there is no other way”. On this view mysticism is something silly, invented by certain mystics “according to their vibes and wishes”.

Is that true? The lecture’s first step in answering is to ask: “What does the Quran say about mysticism? Let’s see.”

Signs, but not for everyone

The lecture turns to Surah al-Rum (chapter 30 of the Quran). It chooses a few verses and notes that “many other verses in the same line” could have been chosen. Each verse in this passage begins with the refrain “And among His signs...” and ends by naming a particular kind of person for whom the sign is meant. That ending is the key. The verse translations in this chapter follow the lecture’s own English wherever it gave one.

وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ أَنْ خَلَقَ لَكُمْ مِنْ أَنْفُسِكُمْ أَزْوَاجًا لِتَسْكُنُوا إِلَيْهَا وَجَعَلَ بَيْنَكُمْ
مَوَدَّةً وَرَحْمَةً إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

*And among His signs is that He created mates for you from yourselves,
that you may dwell in tranquillity with them, and He has put love
and mercy between your hearts: verily in that are signs for those who
reflect.*

Quran 30:21

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation]

What signs? the lecture asks. When we look at the relationship between a man and a woman, do we see a sign of God in it? “Usually,” it says with some irony, “will see the sign of shaitan, isn’t it?” The signs are certainly there, but they are not for everyone. They are for “the people who reflect”.



وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ خَلْقُ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافُ أَلْسِنَتِكُمْ وَالْوَلَوِكُمْ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالَمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

And among His signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the diversity of your tongues and colours: verily in that are signs for those who know.

Quran 30:22

[VERIFY: Qara'i translation]

Here too the lecture asks what we actually see. When we look at the variety of peoples and languages, we tend to see ethnic division, argument and even racism, not a sign of God. Yet the verse says there are signs in this “for the knowledgeable”, “for the learned. Not for everyone.” The lecture then adds a remark that cuts close to home: not most people, “not even most pious people”, and not even most of those who are very strict about the shari’a find signs in this.

وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ مَنَامُكُمْ بِاللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ وَابْتِغَاؤُكُمْ مِّنْ فَضْلِهِ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

And among His signs is the sleep that you take by night and by day, and the quest that you make for livelihood out of His bounty: verily in that are signs for those who hear.

Quran 30:23

[VERIFY: Qara'i translation]

“Aren’t we hearing? Do we hear?” If we truly heard, the lecture asks, why are we not broken down when we meet the signs of Allah, in the way the prophets and the *awliya’ Allah*, the friends of God, break down?



وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ يُرِيكُمْ الْبَرْقَ خَوْفًا وَطَمَعًا وَيُنْزِلُ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً فَيُحْيِي بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

And among His signs, He shows you the lightning, by way both of fear and of hope, and He sends down rain from the sky and with it gives life to the earth after it is dead: verily in that are signs for those who are wise.

Quran 30:24

[VERIFY: Qara'i translation]

Put the four endings side by side: those who reflect, those who know, those who hear, those who are wise. The lecture draws a startling conclusion: "Actually Quran is insulting us." Read honestly, these verses tell us that we do not understand, do not hear, do not reflect and are not learned. "I don't know about you," the lecture says. "I feel that Quran is insulting."

Elsewhere the Quran says something similar, and the lecture notes that it is "almost the same thing": some people have ears and eyes by which they do not hear and see. The next lecture of the series returns to this verse, one that most Quran readers will have met many times. It quotes the part about hearts, eyes and ears:

وَلَقَدْ ذَرَأْنَا لِجَهَنَّمَ كَثِيرًا مِّنَ الْجِنِّ وَالْإِنسِ لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أُذُنٌ لَا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَا أُولَٰئِكَ كَالْأَنْعَامِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْغَافِلُونَ ﴿١٧٩﴾

They have hearts by which they do not understand, they have eyes by which they do not see, and they have ears by which they do not hear. They are like animals, and even worse.

Quran 7:179

[VERIFY: Qara'i translation; the lecture quotes part of the verse]

It is hard to imagine stronger language. But the verse also contains a puzzle, and the lectures use that puzzle to introduce the central image of the whole series.



The inner machine

The puzzle is this. Animals have eyes and ears. Do they not see and hear? Of course they do. An animal sees where it walks, and when it hears a sound it runs away. So what is the Quran comparing? If the people described in the verse are like animals, it cannot be because their eyes and ears have stopped working.

The lecture's answer is that the ear is only an instrument. Its job is to catch the sound, and it does that job perfectly well. "However there is something inside which doesn't catch it. There is a machine inside which is rust and doesn't see these signs." What we see and hear with our senses stays on the surface; it is "superficial". To reach the reality of what we see and hear, something inside the human being has to translate it. Animals see and hear, but they do not have that inner machine. Human beings do have it, but in most of us it is not working. It is, in the lecture's words, "dead and blind".

The lectures give an example that sharpens the point. Those who reject faith, the *kuffar*, also see and hear. If we tell them that they have eyes but do not see, they will laugh. They will say they see better than we do, in more detail and more artistically. The Quran, the lecture says, concedes that they see; what it denies is that they understand. The lectures promise that this "enigma of having and not having, listening and not listening, being and not being" will come up again in the course.

Most of us have heard the Surah al-Rum verses many times. Some of us have even felt, while hearing them, that there is something in them we are not seeing. Usually we accept them out of obedience: the Quran says there are signs here, so there are signs here. That is fine as far as it goes. But the real question is what we must do to *catch* the sign: to hear it, see it and reflect on it. Here the lectures give their first definition of the subject:

Mysticism is all about making one's soul hear, see and reflect. I think this is the summary of mysticism... the summary of Islamic mysticism.

The rest of the series, the lecture says, is about how this can be done, "as it's very difficult". The verse it gives at this point shows how much is at stake:



وَكَايِنَ مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي السَّمٰوٰتِ وَالْاَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ

﴿١٠٥﴾

And how many signs in the heavens and the earth do they pass by? Yet they turn their faces away from them.

Quran 12:105

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation]

“We don’t see. Something is wrong.” The lecture now names the machine directly: it is the soul. The soul is broken; it does not work, and it has to be fixed so that it can catch the signals of God. “And this is not of course a joke and not an easy path. It needs lots of training.”

For a reader new to ‘Irfan, this image may be the most useful thing to carry through the rest of the book. Each later chapter, whether on the soul, the stages of the path, repentance, night prayer, silence or love, can be read as part of one long answer to a single question: how is the inner machine repaired?

The lectures add one more point about this repair. It is often said that mysticism has an end, a final goal at which the journey stops. The lectures disagree. Mysticism “has a beginning and no end”. The beginning is the moment the machine starts working, and then “you see the wonders of this world”.

Not a search for powers

Self-training, the lectures observe, is practised for many different purposes. Many mystics train themselves to gain powers, or to see the future or the past. “But Islamic mysticism is not about this.” Islamic mysticism is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see them. The lecture calls the next verse “very moving”:

قُلْ اَرَاَيْتُمْ اِنْ جَعَلَ اللّٰهُ عَلَيْكُمْ اِلٰلَ سَرْمَدًا اِلٰى يَوْمِ الْقِيَمَةِ مِّنْ اِلٰهٍ غَيْرِ اللّٰهِ يَآتِيْكُمْ بِضِيَآءٍ اَفَلَا تَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٧١﴾

Say: See you? If Allah were to make the night perpetual over you to the Day of Judgment, what god is there other than Allah who can give you enlightenment? Are you not hearing?

Quran 28:71

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation]



“Are you not hearing?” The question at the end of the verse is addressed to the inner hearing, not the outer. What the soul catches, once it is working, are the signals that God is sending to us.

What happens after that cannot be predicted. When the machine is repaired and the soul is lifted up, “god knows what type of signals you can see and hear”. It is not possible for us to reckon what the mystics see and hear. At the very peak of such people, the lecture says, stand the Imams. [QUERY: the transcript at L01 ¶14 reads “the things that the kaafir see and the imam sees of course they are the peak”. Was a different word than “kaafir” intended, such as *kamil* or *awliya*?]

This distinction matters a great deal for anyone setting out to learn about ‘Irfan. Curiosity about wonders, hidden powers and extraordinary experiences is a natural human thing, and it is often the first reason people take an interest in mysticism. The lectures are uncompromising here. Islamic mysticism is “not about any type of power or empowering the soul in a way to do *karamat* and *mojezat*”. And of these, the lecture says flatly: “These are *shirk*.” The chapter returns to this sentence at its close. [QUERY: see the query on L01 ¶32 in the closing section.]

Those brought near

The lectures now turn to the Quran’s own vocabulary for the people they have been describing. There are, they say, two groups of people. In one group the soul works; in the other it does not, or does not work at all. The first are the *‘urafa*, “those who know”, the plural of *‘arif*. The others are the *jahala*, “those who don’t know”. They do not have the capability to know and understand.

The lecture is careful about who it means. It is not talking about the prophets and the Imams, who are “very special *‘urafa*”. Nor is it talking about those who reject faith. Ordinary believers, the *mu’minun*, certainly have understanding. But there are some people, not prophets and not Imams, who have a special understanding beyond that of ordinary believers, and the Quran mentions them.

The first name the lectures give them is *muqarrabun*, “those who are brought near”. This raises an obvious question. Allah is not far away; He is very near. Elsewhere the Quran says He is nearer to a person than their jugular vein [VERIFY: Q 50:16, Qara’i translation]. So in what sense can anyone be “brought



near”? The lecture’s answer is that “probably some veil which was between ordinary people and Allah is taken away”. The muqarrabun understand far better; “this is the meaning of muqarrab”.

ع WORD STUDY: MUQARRABUN

Muqarrabun is a passive form from the root *q-r-b*, “to be near”. Literally it means “those who have been brought near”, which implies that the nearness is given by God, not seized [VERIFY: Arabic lexicon, root q-r-b]. The same root gives *qurb* (nearness), a word that will return often in this book. The lectures point to Surah al-Waqi’a as the place where the Quran separates the muqarrabun from ordinary believers. That surah describes people divided into three groups: the people of the right hand, the people of the left hand, and “the foremost”, who are called the ones brought near (Q 56:7–11) [VERIFY: Qara’i translation and verse numbers]. Near the end of the surah the three groups appear again, with the muqarrabun named first (Q 56:88–94) [VERIFY: verse range]. The lectures add that the muqarrabun are among the *awliya’* Allah, the friends of God.

Earlier teaching by {{LECTURER}}, outside this series, had said that the muqarrabun fall into four categories. The second lecture identifies these with a verse from Surah al-Nisa’. It quotes the opening of the verse and then names the four groups the verse goes on to list:

وَمَنْ يُطِيعِ اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِمْ مِنَ النَّبِيِّينَ
وَالصَّادِقِينَ وَالشُّهَدَاءِ وَالصَّالِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُولَٰئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Anyone who obeys Allah and the Prophet will be of those on whom Allah has bestowed favour: the prophets, the truthful, the witnesses and the righteous.

Quran 4:69

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation; the lecture quotes only the opening and names the four groups separately]

“What is favouring?” the lecture asks. “Certainly it is not wealth or a strong body. It is something else.” The four groups are the prophets (*nabiyyin*), the truthful (*siddiqin*), the witnesses (*shuhada’*) and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three are very special, and “we cannot reach that level”. The muqarrabun include the prophets, the Imams and the siddiqin.

The fourth group, the salihin, is different. The lectures describe them as “very good” and at the bottom of the category of the muqarrabun. The salihin



are those who deserve this favour, or who have the capacity to receive it. It is from among the salihin, the lecture says, that Allah chooses the siddiqin, and from the siddiqin that He chooses the prophets: “It is only from this saleheen that Allah would choose the other 3 categories.” About some of the prophets, the lecture says, Allah explains that He made them prophets because they were among the righteous. [QUERY: confirm with the lecturer that this is meant as a sequence of ranks through which individual prophets pass (salihin, then siddiqin, then prophethood). Some Shia readers may find this contentious, given the station of the prophets and Imams.] The example given is the prophet Lut:

وَأَدْخَلْنَاهُ فِي رَحْمَتِنَا إِنَّهُ مِنَ الصَّالِحِينَ ﴿٧٥﴾

We made him enter into Our mercy; he was of the righteous.

Quran 21:75

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation]

The mercy here, the lecture explains, is “the special mercy”, and Lut deserved it because he belonged to this category. The salihin are people “who understand better than us, who see and hear better than us”.

This is where ordinary people come in. The higher ranks are closed to us, but “ordinary people also can enter into the realm of muqarrabun”. Entering it makes them “completely different from other people”, and the Quran distinguishes them from other believers. It is “very difficult to get into that last category”. “And that is what Islamic Mysticism is about.”

The lectures then draw the contrast with ordinary faith more sharply. What we usually understand is that religion is only the shari’a: follow it, succeed, and go to janna. “Ok that’s fair enough. That is something for ordinary mominoon.” For the muqarrabun, however, “the whole terms and conditions are different”. They are after something else. They are given janna in this world itself, and in the next world they seek something beyond it. They become members of the awliya’ Allah, and they become “the proof of Allah”. “These are actually the true ‘urafa’ or mystics.”

Here the lectures pause on a matter of words. “Mystic” is a very general term, used for Christian, Hindu and Buddhist mystics alike. ‘Arif, by contrast, is “a very nice term which we use in Islam when someone becomes true ‘arif”. This book follows that preference: it speaks of ‘Irfan and the ‘arif wherever it can, and uses “mysticism” only as an English gloss.



A special class of believers in the Quran

If the idea of a special class of believers still sounds like something the mystics invented, the second lecture of the series answers with a series of verses. Each describes believers whose inner life is unlike that of ordinary believers, and each adds something to the picture.

The first is from Surah al-Anfal:

إِنَّمَا الْمُؤْمِنُونَ الَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ اللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ وَإِذَا تُلِيَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ آيَاتُهُ زَادَتْهُمْ إِيمَانًا وَعَلَىٰ رَبِّهِمْ يَتَوَكَّلُونَ ﴿٢﴾

The believers are those who, when the name of Allah is mentioned, their hearts tremble.

Quran 8:2

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation; the lecture quotes the opening of the verse]

“Is there anyone here whose heart trembles when he or she hears the name of Allah?” the lecturer asks the class, and then adds: “Well, even if we have we are not going to reveal this secret.” The serious point follows. What kind of person trembles at a name? You only tremble at something if you already have some idea or experience of it. If someone mentions a thing that frightens you, you go numb because you already know what it is. So these believers tremble at the name of Allah because they *know* Allah. They are not ordinary believers.

The second verse opens Surah al-Mu’minun:

قَدْ أَفْلَحَ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ ﴿١﴾ الَّذِينَ هُمْ فِي صَلَاتِهِمْ خَاشِعُونَ ﴿٢﴾

The believers have succeeded: those who are humble in their prayers.

Quran 23:1-2

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation; the lecture renders only the second verse ("the mominoon who are humble in their prayers")]

“It is not me certainly,” the lecture says, “and many of you might not be like this.” The word translated “humble” is *khashi’*, and the lecture explains that it means more than humility. A *khashi’* is someone who is broken: someone who has experienced something that brings them down inside themselves. When such believers stand before Allah in salah, they break down, and they do so “because of their experience that they have of Allah”.



That brings the lecture to what it calls the heart of the matter: “Can Allah be experienced at all? This is what mysticism is all about. Can we have a way or a canal or a path to Allah?”

The next verse goes higher. The lecture calls it one of the great verses of the Quran, one that “only people who have high knowledge can understand”:

شَهِدَ اللَّهُ أَنَّهُ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَالْمَلَائِكَةُ وَأُولُوا الْعِلْمِ قَائِمًا بِالْقِسْطِ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ ﴿١٨﴾

There is no god but He: that is the witness of Allah, His angels, and those endued with knowledge.

Quran 3:18

[VERIFY: Qara'i translation; the lecture renders part of the verse]

Allah has knowledge of His own oneness, His *tawhid*, and He bears witness to it. We also have some knowledge of *tawhid*, but it cannot be compared with His. The angels bear witness too, and so do certain human beings: *ulu al-ilm*, “those who are endued with knowledge”. This, the lecture says, is “another expression of ‘arif”. The ‘urafa’, those who have ma‘rifah, bear witness to the *tawhid* of Allah.

This is why the lectures insist that *tawhid* is “not as simple as just saying that there is no god but Allah”. That is its simplest meaning, the one we all understand. To understand it more deeply, the lecture says, “we cannot live by our intellect”. “We have to start and ignite that machine inside us, the soul. It’s only that part of us that can grab *tawhid*.” The lecture recalls a teaching that each verse of the Quran has seven layers of depth, beneath each of those seventy, and beneath each of those seven hundred [VERIFY: source of this tradition; the lecture introduces it with “we have heard”]. The point is that the same verse, the same concept, is understood at different depths by different people.

Then comes Surah *Fatir*:

وَمِنَ النَّاسِ وَالْدَّوَابِّ وَالْأَنْعَامِ مُخْتَلِفٌ أَلْوَنُهُ كَذَلِكَ إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى اللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ الْعُلَمَاءُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَزِيزٌ غَفُورٌ ﴿٢٨﴾

Only those who are possessed of knowledge have fear of Allah.

Quran 35:28



[VERIFY: Qara’i translation; the lecture quotes part of the verse]

All of us fear Allah in some way, the lecture observes, but most of us fear His punishment more than we fear Him. There are some people who fear Him and not His punishment, with a kind of fear “which we cannot explain. It’s not fear of punishment. It is something else.”

The lectures name two more Quranic expressions for such people. One is *ulu al-albab*, “those who have inner intellect”. The other is the *awliya’ Allah*, the friends of God:

﴿٦٢﴾ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَوْلِيَاءُ اللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ

Verily on the friends of Allah there is no fear, nor shall they grieve.

Quran 10:62

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation]

Again, this is a group of people who are different from us. How does someone become a friend of Allah and connect to Him so closely? It depends, the lecture says, on how the word *wali* is translated. The lecture leaves the point there and moves on to the next verse; the meaning of wilaya is taken up again with the Munajat Sha‘baniyyah below.

The last verse in this series is from Surah al-Nahl:

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَالِحًا مِّنْ ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنْثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهٗ حَيٰوةً طَيِّبَةً
وَلَنَجْزِيَنَّهُمْ أَجْرَهُم بِأَحْسَنِ مَا كَانُوا يَعْمَلُونَ ﴿٩٧﴾

Whoever does good, male or female, and is a believer, We will give them a clean and pure life.

Quran 16:97

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation; the English here condenses the lecture’s paraphrase]

The lecture notices that “does good”, *‘amila salihan*, comes from the same root as salihin. Whoever does a righteous deed as a believer becomes one of the salihin: the lowest of the four ranks, and the only one open to ordinary people. [QUERY: the lecture says here (L02 ¶18–19) that whoever acts righteously as a believer “becomes from saleheen”, but it also says it is “very difficult to get into that last category” (L01 ¶15). How does ordinary righteous action (*‘amila salihan*) relate to this difficult entry?] To such people Allah promises a *hayat tayyiba*, a “good life”. The lecture explains *tayyiba* as clean and pure:



pure “from the filth of this world”. Such people “live in this world but they do not live in the filth of this world”. They rise above the worldly concerns that infect everyone else. “And this hayat tayyiba is of course what mystics are after.”

This, the lecture concludes, is enough of an introduction to show who the mystics are, and why they put themselves through “so much hardship, lots of training and purification to find a glimpse and experience of Allah”. They do it because love of Him “has been put in their heart and that’s why they are glad to seek”.

The Quran, then, does not leave the question of mysticism to the mystics’ “vibes and wishes”. It describes believers whose hearts tremble, who break down in prayer, who bear witness to tawhid with knowledge, who fear God rather than His punishment, and who live a pure life in the middle of the world. The lecture grants that following the shari’a leads to janna: “Ok that’s fair enough.” Its reply to the jurists is that the Quran itself points to something more.

Words too big for us: the Munajat Sha‘baniyyah

After the Quran, the lectures turn to the supplications of the Imams (‘a). If we want to know what the ‘urafa’ want, they say, we can look at what the Imams asked God for. The first text they choose is one that many readers will know well: the *Munajat Sha‘baniyyah*, the intimate prayer of the month of Sha‘ban. A *munajat* is an intimate, whispered prayer addressed directly to God.

✧ THE MUNAJAT SHA‘BANIYYAH

The lecture says that the Munajat Sha‘baniyyah is reported from Imam ‘Ali (‘a) and from Imam Zayn al-‘Abidin (‘a), and that all the Imams used to recite it. The traditional report places this recitation in the month of Sha‘ban [VERIFY: Iqbal al-A‘mal of Sayyid Ibn Tawus, citing Ibn Khalawayh]. It is printed among the practices of Sha‘ban in *Mafatih al-Jinan*, the widely used prayer manual compiled by Shaykh ‘Abbas Qummi [VERIFY: Mafatih al-Jinan, practices of Sha‘ban]. In Shia communities, including Khoja jama‘ats, it is commonly recited during Sha‘ban, the month that leads up to Ramadan, and many people know its opening lines by heart [VERIFY: confirm the details of Khoja practice with the user, e.g. when and where it is recited in jama‘at]. Imam Khomeini is often quoted as giving it special praise among the supplications of the Imams [VERIFY: source of this statement]. The lecture’s own advice is simple: recite it in Sha‘ban “as much as you can”.



The lecture admits to a certain puzzlement. “Sometimes I question why we are told to recite such words.” Giving these words to ordinary believers, it says, is “like if you tell a primary school boy to read books of university”. These words come from the peak of the understanding and longing of the muqarrabun, and yet we are asked to say them. The lecture then reads through some of the lines, giving its own translations. The renderings below follow the lecture [VERIFY: check each line against Mafatih al-Jinan, Munajat Sha‘baniyyah, and a published translation].

The first request is: *My Lord, grant me complete severance of my relation with everything else.* The Arabic word for this severance is *inqita’*: cutting oneself off. Is it good, the lecture asks, to cut oneself off completely from everything else? “Well, in the heart yes.” The Quran says the same in Surah al-Muzzammil:

وَاذْكُرْ اسْمَ رَبِّكَ وَتَبَتَّلْ إِلَيْهِ تَبْتِيلًا ﴿٨﴾

Cut off from everything and devote yourself to Him wholeheartedly.

Quran 73:8

[VERIFY: Qara’i translation; the lecture renders only the second half of the verse]

The Quranic word for this is *tabattul*. This severance, the lecture notes, goes beyond the sensitivity to signs described in Surah al-Rum.

The next line asks: *and enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at You.* Here the machine image returns. If our physical eyes work, why do we not see the signs? Because there is another mechanism, the heart, which has to take in what the eyes receive, and it does not, “because it’s blind”. The du’a asks for the eyes of the heart to be given light.

This raises an obvious objection, and the lecture states it plainly. “What the mystics mean looking at god? Is it something possible at all? Quran says that you can never see god.” The verse usually cited is the one that says that vision does not perceive Him [VERIFY: Q 6:103, Qara’i translation]. People who are not familiar with the language of the mystics, the lecture says, sometimes conclude that such wording is a mistake. The du’a itself speaks of the eyes of the *heart*, not the eyes of the head. Shia teaching rejects any physical sight of God [VERIFY: a held source on Shia kalam regarding ru’ya, e.g. a Tabataba’i or Mutahhari text]. A well-known report from Imam ‘Ali (‘a) makes the same distinction. Asked whether he had seen his Lord, he is reported to have said that eyes do not see Him but hearts perceive Him through the realities of faith [VERIFY: Nahj



al-Balagha, the sermon in reply to Dhi’lib al-Yamani; paraphrase only, wording to be supplied from a held source]. The lectures promise to explain later what “looking at the face of Allah” means.

The du’a then goes further still: *until the eyes of the hearts penetrate the veils of light*. The mystics, the lecture says, speak of veils, *hujub*, both of light and of darkness. A seeker must pass through them until they reach the very origin of Allah’s grandeur, His ‘*azama* and *kibriya*’. And so the du’a continues: *and reach the source of grandeur*. “This is of course something which we cannot understand,” the lecture admits. When we speak of Allah, we speak of something beyond our understanding. Yet this is exactly what the ‘urafa’ want: to know Him, to look at Him, and to be drawn towards Him. To do that, they must first be cut off from everything else. The lecture reads the du’a as an order of steps. First comes severance; then the eyes of the heart are enlightened; then they penetrate the veils of light and look into the source of grandeur.

Then: *and let our souls be suspended by the glory of Your sanctity*. What does it mean for a soul to hang suspended from the glory of God’s holiness? The lecture does not claim that we can grasp it. But it adds a principle worth remembering for every difficult text in this book: “If we don’t know what they are talking about it doesn’t mean that it is senseless and meaningless.”

Another line asks: *My Lord, make me one of those whom You call and they respond, and when You look at them they are struck by Your majesty*. This, the lecture says, is “something like prophets do. You call and they respond.” When God looks inside their souls, they are “thunder struck” by the majesty, the *jalah*, that they see. “This is munajat-e-shabaniyah. We cannot say that this is not good.”

The lecture then gives its advice. All the Imams recited this prayer, and we are told to recite it in the month of Sha‘ban, and the lecture recommends reciting it “as much as you can”. Of course we do not understand many of its meanings. “But we have been honoured.” These words are “not of our level”, and yet we have been allowed to say them. It is as if Allah says: come and recite this, and perhaps, if you are sincere, I will grant it to you. “What immah wanted, Allah granted them.”

Most of the other lines of the munajat, the lecture says, are like these. One more is singled out: *My God, place me among the people of Your wilaya*. The word *wilaya* is translated in many ways: friendship, closeness, guardianship. Here the lecture draws out two meanings. One is ma‘rifah: understanding



God, knowing Him, looking at Him. The other is love for Him. Ma‘rifah and love are “the true meaning for wilayatik by which they can fly”, and they are exactly what the du‘a asks for: “incessant love for Allah and marifah which will ever be increasing”. This, the lecture adds, will happen only after the machine has been fixed and starts to show the signals of Allah.

The line continues: *in the position of one who hopes for an increase in Your love*. The person described is one who has found a passionate love of remembering God, so that he remembers only Him. The lecture quotes the line that follows, which speaks of this longing for His remembrance, but says “I need to explain” and does not go on to explain it.

Can a human being reach this?

Having read words like these, it is natural to ask whether any of it is realistic. The lecture links the munajat back to Surah al-Waqi‘a and its separation of believers from the muqarrabun, and then asks directly: is it possible for a human being to reach that level of understanding, knowledge and love of Allah?

The answer begins with a hard saying. “We wrongly call ourselves human being. We are not yet human beings. We are animals who have potential to become human beings.” We were created as animals with the capacity to become human, like the prophets, who are “real human beings”. This picks up the verse from Surah al-A‘raf about those who are “like animals”, and gives it a hopeful turn. The animal state is where we begin, not where we must stay.

Then comes the hopeful part. “A human being has the capacity to become a friend of god. Allah has created us at this strength and he wants us to reach that strength.” The tragedy is what we have done with that capacity: instead of becoming His friends, “we have become his enemy”.

What makes the awliya’ Allah different? How do they manage to fix the machine in the middle of ordinary life? The lectures note that they use *awliya’ Allah*, “the friends of God”, as a synonym for the ‘urafa’, the mystics. They then turn to a description of the awliya’ by Imam ‘Ali (‘a) in *Nahj al-Balagha*. In the lecture’s paraphrase, the Imam says that the friends of God are those who look at the inward side of the world while other people look at its outward side, at “what is on the surface”. The awliya’ look deeper, and that is why they please Allah [VERIFY: Nahj al-Balagha; the lecture calls it "sermon 432", but this is probably Saying 432 in the Subhi al-Salih numbering].



Why can they do this when we cannot? The transcript is unclear here. It says that the awliya’ “busy themselves with 29:49” while other people busy themselves “in the imaging”. Q 29:49 speaks of the Quran as clear signs in the hearts of those who have been given knowledge, so the contrast may possibly be between those signs and outward things [VERIFY: Q 29:49, Qara’i translation]. [QUERY: L01 ¶26 gives only the verse number "29:49" and contrasts it with "the imaging". What contrast was intended?]

The lecture’s example is clearer. Being rich is not the problem; the problem is getting busy with wealth. [QUERY: L01 ¶26 reads "it is wrong according to shariah to become rich. It is nothing wrong if you are rich." This chapter takes the second sentence as the intended sense (wealth is not wrong in itself), because the rest of the passage supports it. Please confirm.] If you are preoccupied with such things, “you can never reach that stage of awliyaAllah”. The awliya’ “never think about themselves. They always think about god.” This does not mean they abandon the world. Like everyone else they have families, friends and a place in society. But in their hearts they are cut off from all else, “completely away and aloof from what goes on with other people”. The lecture recommends reading the rest of Imam ‘Ali’s description directly, calling it “a very nice prescription of awliyaAllah”.

Not a hermit: the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers

The second supplication the lectures read is from the *Sahifa Sajjadiyya*, the collection of supplications associated with Imam Zayn al-‘Abidin (‘a). It belongs to the group known as the Fifteen Whispered Prayers, the *Munajat al-Khamsa ‘Ashar*. The lines quoted are from the one usually called the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers, *Munajat al-Muhibbin* [VERIFY: Sahifa Sajjadiyya, Munajat al-Muhibbin; the lecture names only "Munajat Khamsa ‘Ashar"].

◆ WHO'S WHO: IMAM ZAYN AL-‘ABIDIN AND THE SAHIFA

‘Ali ibn al-Husayn (‘a) is the fourth Imam. He is known as Zayn al-‘Abidin (“the adornment of the worshippers”) and al-Sajjad (“the one who prostrates much”) [VERIFY: titles and their meanings, standard Shia biographical source, e.g. al-Mufid, Kitab al-I-shad]. He was the son of Imam al-Husayn (‘a) and was present at Karbala, where illness kept him from the battle [VERIFY: al-Mufid, Kitab al-Irshad]. After the tragedy he was taken captive with the women and children to Kufa and Damascus [VERIFY: al-Mufid, Kitab al-Irshad]. He spent the rest of his life in Medina [VERIFY: biographical source], and he is buried in the cemetery of al-Baqi’ [VERIFY: burial place, and date of



death, usually given as 94 or 95 AH]. Much of his teaching survives in supplications. The *Sahifa Sajjadiyya* gathers them, and it has been called “the Psalms of the Household of Muhammad” [VERIFY: *Sahifa*, translator’s introduction]. The Fifteen Whispered Prayers are usually printed with it as an appendix and transmitted separately [VERIFY: transmission of the Fifteen Munajat, e.g. via Bihar al-Anwar].

The lecture begins with a thought experiment. If you read this prayer without knowing who wrote it, you might think it came from someone who had left society, lived in a cave and spent his whole life devoted completely to Allah. Yet it is from Imam Zayn al-‘Abidin (‘a). The lecture invites us to “look what he says”. The prayer illustrates what the lectures mean when they say the *awliya’* are cut off from everything else “in the heart”. Here are the lines as the lecture renders them [VERIFY: each line against the *Sahifa*, *Munajat al-Muhibbin*, and a published translation].

My God, who can have tasted the sweetness of Your love and then be after anything else? If you are still after other things, the lecture says, then “you have not tasted the sweetness of his love”.

And who is there who has become familiar with Your nearness and then wants to go somewhere else? Someone who has known the familiarity of God’s nearness has no wish to go elsewhere.

The prayer then asks to be placed among a particular group of people, and it describes them line by line: *those whom You have chosen for Your nearness and Your friendship; whom You have purified completely for Your affection and love; whom You have made eager to meet You and content with Your decree; to whom You have given the gift of looking at Your face*. Here again is the language of “looking”, and again the lecture defers the explanation: “Now it seems very meaningless but when we go through the course of the lesson we will know what is looking at the face of Allah.”

The prayer goes on: *whom You have given refuge from the pain of separation from You*. The lecture pauses here on the difference between two kinds of people at prayer. For some of us, when we call on Allah, He seems completely absent. “We want to cry into the sky because we are very far away from him.” For others, when they call Him, they feel His presence and His response so heavily that they break down and faint, “like the *immah*”.

The prayer continues: *whom You have chosen for Your true knowledge, made worthy of Your worship, and whose heart You have captivated with Your will*.



The word behind “captivated” is from *hayam*, and the lecture says it means more than captivation: a love that “never ever is quenched”. It connects the word with a tradition about angels called the *muhayyamin*, angels “burnt in the love of Allah”, who look at Him in such a way that they cannot turn their faces away [VERIFY: source of the tradition of the muhayyamin angels]. Elsewhere, the lecture adds, there is mention of angels standing in a row, watching God so intently that when other angels ask them anything, they cannot hear and cannot see. They are completely absorbed in Him.

Some mystics have felt something of this state. Some, after finding it, could not speak until the end of their lives. The lecture does not hold this up as an ideal: “I don’t say it is good because if they have enough capacity they can come back like the prophet goes to *meraj* and comes back.” The Prophet ﷺ rose in his *mi’raj*, his ascension, and came back, and that return, the lecture says, “needs great capacity”. The lecture quotes one more phrase from the prayer before moving on: *and You have made his heart burn with the love of seeking You*. [GAP: at L01 ¶31 the lecturer says, “InshaAllah I will find the translation and put it here”; the fuller translation he intended to provide is not in the transcript.]

Seeking, and nothing else

“This is how mystics works,” the lecture concludes. “It is actually seeking and nothing else. It is not about any type of power or empowering the soul in a way to do *karamat* and *mojezat*. These are *shirk*.” *Karamat* are the wonders attributed to saints, and *mu’jizat* are the miracles of the prophets; *shirk* is associating something with God. The lecture’s sentence is stated without qualification, and this book reports it as it stands. One possible reading is that the lecture means that seeking such powers as the goal of training the soul is *shirk*, not that the miracles themselves are. That reading is the editors’, not the lecture’s. [QUERY: L01 ¶32 reads “It is not about any type of power or empowering the soul in a way to do *karamat* and *mojezat*. These are *shirk*.” Please confirm the intended sense, since the Quran affirms the miracles of the prophets. Is it the seeking of such powers that is *shirk*?] What Islamic mysticism wants, the lecture ends, is “*Marefah* and the love of Allah”. How the mystics pursue it, and what they find, is the subject of the rest of the course.

It is worth looking back at the path this chapter has taken, because the later chapters build on it.



- It began with a fair challenge: the obligatory duties are enough for janna, so why do more?
- It answered from the Quran. The signs of God are everywhere, but they are for “those who reflect”, “those who know”, “those who hear” and “those who are wise”. Most of us, by that measure, pass the signs by.
- It located the problem inside us. The eyes and ears work, but the inner machine, the soul, is rusted and blind. ‘Irfan is the long training by which that machine is fixed, so that the soul can hear, see and reflect.
- It set Islamic ‘Irfan apart from power-seeking mysticism. Powers are not the goal. In the lecture’s words, karamat and mu’jizat “are shirk” [QUERY: intended sense; see the query on L01 ¶32 above].
- It showed that the Quran itself speaks of a special class of believers: the muqarrabun and the salihin, those whose hearts tremble, the khashi’, those endued with knowledge, the awliya’ Allah, and those granted a pure life. Of the four ranks, only the salihin are open to ordinary people, and that rank is very hard to enter.
- Finally, it let the Imams (‘a) describe the goal in their own words, through the Munajat Sha‘baniyyah and the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers: severance from everything else, the eyes of the heart filled with light, love that is never quenched, and ma‘rifah that keeps increasing.

For readers from a community that recites these prayers, the chapter’s most important point may be the simplest one. The texts of ‘Irfan are not foreign to us. Many of us already recite them, in Sha‘ban and in the quiet of our own homes. What the lectures offer is a way of reading them as what they are: the words of people who were seeking God and nothing else, which we have been honoured to be allowed to say.

♦ REFLECTION

The lecture compares reciting the Munajat Sha‘baniyyah to a primary school child reading university books, and yet it calls being allowed to recite it an honour. This Sha‘ban, or the next time you open the Sahifa, choose a single line from the prayers in this chapter. You might choose “grant me complete severance of my relation with everything else”, or “who can have tasted the sweetness of Your love and then be after anything else?” Say it slowly, once a day, and ask yourself honestly: what, at this moment, am I “after” instead of Him? The question is not meant to bring despair. In the lecture’s words, Allah “has created us at this strength and he wants us to reach that strength”.



In the next chapter the lectures move from introduction to the course proper, beginning with its vocabulary. They look at the words 'Irfan, ma'rifah, Sufism and mysticism. They then examine the two kinds of knowledge, knowledge that is acquired and knowledge that is present in the soul, that explain how the inner machine “knows” at all.